# Teacher Role and Creating Sacred Space #1



## Basic Ritual Elements

Ritual is a primordial, elemental language across cultures.

**Earth** Stones, altars, burial of objects, ashes, statues, sand
**Air** Prayers, blessings, songs, healing words, mantra, drums, bells, gongs, fans
**Fire** Candles, purifying fire, incense, smudge, burning objects/writings to release the old
**Water** Sprinkling, pouring, dunking, floating away
**Nature** Branches, flowers, bower, fruits and offerings
**Space** Visualizations, meditations, protected boundary
**Fabric** Sacred cord, shawls, hats, gowns, robes
**Arts** Paintings, dance, music, movement, procession
**Gestures** Bows, hugs, handshake, embrace, gaze, touch

## Some Simple Ritual Examples

### BABY BLESSING

Speak of welcoming new member into the community.
Recognize each is a Buddha in a new form.
Each has a unique and singular song and innocence: "Do not let me forget who I really am".
See parenting as guardianship of a child's spirit … love and responsibility.
Read from the Metta Sutta "like a mother who holds her only beloved child."
Explain that they now have a perfect Zen master or guru living with them to train them in patience, wisdom, generosity, mindfulness, equanimity, etc.
Bless them that they may be held in our hearts communally, with lives filled with grace, courage, laughter, ease, etc.
Create a small blessing cord for the baby and chant the three refuges yourself that they may remember to see the Buddha in every being and follow the way of the Dharma.
Tie it on and invite the community to chant the sacred mantra … "Row, row, row, your boat."

### WEDDING ELEMENTS

Meet with the bride and groom and always follow their vision.
Create a sacred space … altar, bower, flowers etc.
Envision their entrance … music, flower girls, accompanied by parents or best friends.
Welcome as minister/officiant.
Explain the purpose of bringing together community, beauty and ritual. Talk about marriage and the need to have community as witness and container.
Poems, readings or songs. Look at the book *Into the Garden* for wedding poems and scripts.
If Buddhist, three refuges and/or precepts and/or chant with an explanation.
Exchange of vows, memorized or read, or repeated after the minister.

Exchange of rings … symbol of untarnished wholeness, etc. Ring bearer.
Ritual elements … the lighting of candles, exchange of garlands.
Pronouncement and kiss.
Metta meditation.
Water blessing ritual with wand of flowers in bowl of holy water blessed with cord by the group.
Ending … music, chant, prayer, poem, balloons, etc.
How to exit.

#### FUNERAL ELEMENTS

Create a sacred space.
Music and lighting of candles.
Prayers or chants, opening poems or readings.
Welcoming all and speaking about death and memorials and Dharma teachings.
Talk about the value of grief.
Invite several important and close people to speak … videos or photos
Invite people to make small groups of three to five to tell stories to one another about the deceased.
Then ask a handful of people from the groups to share stories to everyone.
Short reading of sutras or from "Tibetan Book of the Dead" (in *A Path with Heart*).
Scatter ashes, plant trees, ceremonial burial, burying or offering small Buddhas.
Pouring of water from glass pitcher into glass bowl while offering merit, perhaps white cord.
Group Metta meditation.
108 bells.

#### HOUSE BLESSING

Chant, offer prayers, meditate together, offer Metta.
Water sprinkle.
Create written blessing over door.

## Other Rituals

#### GRIEF, DIVORCE, FORGIVENESS, RESOLVING CONFLICT, HEALING

Create communal altars, outdoor altars, including stones, bells, candles.
Offer prayers, share our stories.
Writing, burying or burning letters to the dead and the living.
Metta chants, refuges, merit sharing.
Forgiveness practices, Pavarana (see "Covering Mud with Straw," Chapter 48 in *Old Path White Clouds* by Thich Nhat Hanh).

## Meditation

### CALLING ON YOUR FUTURE SELF*

*Please feel free to substitute "High Self," "Awakened Heart" or any words that point to the most evolved expression of your being.

Find a comfortable posture, close your eyes and come into stillness. Take several long deep breaths to collect your attention. See if with each outbreath you can release any tension that has accumulated in your body.

Now imagine you could journey into the future—10–20 years ahead—and encounter your future self, an older, awake, evolved version of yourself.

Visualize your future self's home. Picture where your future self is in this home, and how your future self looks—clothing, hair, facial expression, and especially the look in their eyes as you meet. Notice what their presence is like, how it feels to be with them.

Sense that you are letting your future self know about your emerging experience in teaching mindfulness and compassion. Let them know whatever feels most engaging or challenging, including wherever you feel most vulnerable, insecure or uncertain.

Ask any questions you want about fulfilling your potential in teaching… and just listen with an open heart.

Before leaving, find out if there is a message your future self wants you to remember … something that will serve you in the moments of your current life.

Then take a moment to imagine the wisdom and heart of your future self filling you.

Return to this moment and sense how the love and wisdom of your most evolved being lives in you now and always. Trust that, with practice, you will naturally access, teach, and live from this awakened heart with more and more ease.